

Remember to demonstrate learning based upon the assigned course reading materials.

In order to demonstrate learning, students are expected to rely heavily on the assigned readings.

A high quality assignment will weave together, or synthesize, the main thesis of several assigned sources together, and build a Primary Assignment argument based upon this process. This form of synthesis is a high-level thinking skill that takes time and practice to master.

How does one determine what the main theme of an assigned reading article?

1. Read an article.
 - a. Be aware that an author is writing the article to inform the reader of an idea or argument they want the reader to understand. They are communicating to the reader through the written word.
 - b. By examining the article's title you may be able to predict what the article is about.
 - c. The opening and closing paragraphs to most articles are of particular importance.
 - i. The opening paragraph(s) contain the thesis statement of an article. A thesis statement tells you what the article is about and provides a roadmap to the rest of the article.
 - ii. The closing paragraph(s) are the conclusion and usually restate the position of the article in concise terms.
 - iii. The body or the middle section of the paper lays out the author's arguments in support of the thesis statement.
 - d. By focusing on the thesis and conclusion of the article you can quickly determine what the author is trying to convey.
 - e. If an article is challenging, read the first two paragraphs and last four paragraphs of the article. In the first two paragraphs, you should be able to find the author's thesis statement or reason why she wrote the paper.
 - f. In the closing four paragraphs, the author usually reiterates the points of her arguments: not always but often. The closing comments in the article often include a recap or summary of their persuasive argument.
 - g. At this point you should have a pretty good idea of the author's argument. With this understanding, you should now be able to read the whole assigned article.
2. After you have finished reading the article, write down what you think the author wanted the reader to know from having read the article. THAT should be the main theme.

Said slightly differently: ***After you have read an assigned reading article***, ask yourself, "Why did the author write this? What was the message the author wanted the reader to take away from having read

this article?" The answer to that question, which should be a sentence or perhaps two, is the main theme of the assigned reading article. In order to demonstrate learning, use the assigned article's main theme in your Primary Assignment each week. If you cannot summarize the author's intent in, at most, two sentences, you either want to re-read, or skim, the article, or confer with a student in your class. Sharing and exchanging ideas with fellow students is not only a good idea, but it is also encouraged.